







Flagship Initiatives

YOUTH, FARMERS AND ENTREPRENEURS

1. Youth Engagement through Empowered Youth Organisations (YESS)

In Meghalaya, the percentage of population under the age of 35 is 74 per cent, much higher than the national average. This large segment of the state's population, if provided with the right opportunities, could become the key agents for social change, economic development, and technological innovation. Their potential was demonstrated during the outbreak of the Covid-19 pandemic in the state. The youth played a significant role in the on-ground management of various activities such as contact tracing, planning and delivery of essential supplies and awareness campaigns.

There are more than 3,000 registered youth clubs and organisations in Meghalaya, working for the development, engagement, and rejuvenation of the youth. However, for them to be able to take concrete action, which will have a larger impact on youth development, it is imperative that the state government empowers these youth organisations enabling them to take positive action.

This programme, therefore, has been formulated in pursuance to the State Youth Policy notified in 2021, which outlines the commitment of the Government of Meghalaya to youth engagement, empowerment, and rejuvenation. The Conrad Sangma government plans to channelise the energies of the youth in the right direction by giving stimulus to youth at the required levels.

Financial aid is provide to the youth clubs and associations working towards the development of the youth. The programme aims to empower the youth to plan and implement grassroot level programs and activities pertaining to key themes affecting the youth. An annual corpus fund has been created to provide financial benefit up to 1 Lakh to the registered not for profit youth clubs, organisations, and associations. This has been planned in a manner to create a nurturing ecosystem for the youth to seek excellence without the financial or any societal constraints.

TARGETED STAKEHOLDERS

This programme shall extend financial aid to registered entities focusing on youth development and empowerment such as:

a. Societies and cooperatives
b. Voluntary organisations
c. Youth clubs
d. Not for profit organisations
e. Socio-cultural clubs
f. Alumni associations
g. Community level youth institutions/organisations/ groups

2. FOCUS—Farmers' Collectivization for Upscaling Production and Marketing System

The Government of Meghalaya launched the FOCUS (Farmers' Collectivization for Upscaling of Production and Marketing Systems) programme in March 2021 with an aim to increase production, improve productivity, facilitate credit linkages and strengthen access to markets for the producers engaged in activities such as farming, livestock rearing and related activities. The FOCUS program identifies production clusters of marketable produce, prioritizes value chain analysis of the products and forms bottom-up small collectives known as Producer Groups (PGs).

FOCUS Beneficiaries Testimonial:

- ***John Gilbert M Sangma***, Pepper Farmer, SWGH (FOCUS)

"Our producer group received 75,000 rupees for farming activities. Together, we are using the funds for our farming operations to achieve better results. My income from pepper cultivation has already risen to 3 lakh rupees. Thanks to the Government of Meghalaya for providing us the FOCUS program."

- ***Marcelina Ch Marak***, Dachimagre PG, WGH (FOCUS)

"We were starting our producer group with 10 members of our village. The government of Meghalaya gave us 50,000 rupees as financial assistance under FOCUS scheme. We began making banana chips through our PG. We are currently making good profits by selling the banana chips in our local market. We are grateful to the Honorable Chief Minister, Shri Conrad K. Sangma, and the Government of Meghalaya."The programme's objective is to reach all the 4.5 lakh rural households in Meghalaya. In about 1.5 years, the programme has benefitted over 2.5 lakh households.

Take the example of Armstrong Shylla. She runs a producer group (PG) named Na Dyngkhong Ki Nongrep in Mawkyrwat Block of South West Khasi Hills. Under FOCUS, this group of 15 members, received a mobilization support fund cheque of Rs 75,000. The PG invested this fund in buying quality seeds and better farm equipment and in packaging the produce better. This has resulted in surplus production and higher value for the produce.

Targeted to support farmers market and cooperative societies, the FOCUS programme has made a huge impact in furthering the collectivization movement in the State. The programme covers the entire umbrella of producers which includes not just those that are involved in farming and livestock rearing but even those who are engaged in other related activities such as handloom and handicrafts. The support money is provided as a grant to the producer groups to aid them in their agricultural activities. It has been observed that a large share of the support, given to the PGs, is being used by them to purchase agricultural inputs, the purchase of piglets and the aggregation of produce for processing and marketing. The feedback from the producers were overwhelming. However there was a gap in delivering the funds to the beneficiaries due to which few members didn't receive the benefits on time.

3. FOCUS+ —transition from collectives to individual

The FOCUS+ (FOCUS plus) programme has been conceptualized as an extension to the FOCUS and as a pivot from collectives to individuals. The collectivization movement heralded by the FOCUS programme has brought a fundamental and transformational shift in the agriculture and allied sectors in the state. While the government will continue to implement and expand the FOCUS programme, it is also felt that making the programme comprehensive and more impactful by giving greater agency to individuals is the way forward. This will be in line with other programmes such as the PM-KISAN wherein the individual farmers are being made the anchors and given the responsibility for the overall growth of the primary sector.

FOCUS+ could be availed by the individual producer after being a part of a producer group. They'll receive a FOCUS+ card upon which, Rs 5000 will be disbursed in tranches. The beneficiaries can undertake activities related to agri-value chain development. This amount will be in addition to the corpus of Rs 5,000 that they are already eligible for as part of being a member of a producer group.

4. PRIME—Promotion and Incubation of Market Driven Enterprise (Rural & Urban)

Entrepreneurs are provided with kick start grants up to Rs 5 lakh; interest and collateral free loans up to Rs 25 lakh. In PRIME Urban E-championship Challenge, 2021, more than 1,600 applicants registered.